Kennedy moved to send a high-level mission for an assessment of India's needs, speed up delivery of essential spare parts to the Indian Air Force, expand the group of US military advisers working with their Indian counterparts, and send an aircraft carrier to the Bay of Bengal to deter China. Despite Galbraith's concerns that the Indian Air Force taking to the air and American intervention would escalate the conflict, Washington was also "in the process of drafting a favorable reply to Nehru's air cover proposal."[267] Before a reply could be sent, however, the Chinese declared a ceasefire on November 21.

The Tilt

There continues to be debate between Nehru-baiters and Nehru-supporters on the question of whether nonalignment died in November 1962 with that request. The answer depends on the definition of *nonalignment*. If it is considered to be the refusal to seek military assistance, then policymakers did indeed jettison nonalignment. Nehru acknowledged that India would not "normally" have sought aid, but "when one has to struggle for existence, one has to do this kind of thing."[268] And that ask was not just for equipment. Even after the war, Nehru reiterated the request for defense arrangements "so that [the] US Air Force can assist the Indian Air Force should an emergency suddenly arise."[269]

If nonalignment is not aligning against anyone, then, too, policymakers abandoned it. As even Nehru admitted just after the war, "There is no nonalignment vis-à-vis China."[270] B. K. Nehru later commented that "we had become in fact the allies of the United States in their confrontation *at least against China.*"[271] On the other hand, if nonalignment means the lack of participation in a formal alliance, then India did not give up nonalignment. Nor did it stop seeking to diversify its partnerships and its dependence. In November 1962, it just learned the hard way that diversification requires the availability of multiple willing partners—and at that time, with the Soviet option unavailable, India had little choice but to tilt toward the US.

One could argue that the availability of a US option for India to turn toward was a benefit of its policy of diversification. But the risk remained that the US might not have been willing to aid India. Even given American